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For Clover, ‘the math stopped working’

Once-visionary company faced a shift in tastes and increasing financial pressure

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

Ayr Muir founded Clover with one food truck near MIT and spent 15 years turning it into one of Greater Boston’s best-known fast-casual chains. On Tuesday, after two years watching from afar, Muir said he found out the entire chain would close through an email sent to board members.

“I’m devastated,” said Muir, whose only remaining connection to

the company is being a minority shareholder and board member.

To Muir, the email represented the end of an experiment he began in 2008 with the single food truck and a dream to disrupt Boston’s food scene by serving millions of sustainable, vegetarian meals as efficiently as a burger joint.

Clover rode a rising trend of health-conscious dining into a rapid expansion, opening dozens of brick-and-mortar stores throughout the

region. But as interest in meat alternatives faded in recent years, the company was unable to maintain its lofty vision.

On Tuesday, Clover’s executives said it would close its 12 remaining quick-serve restaurants and kiosks for good at the end of business on Thursday after more than 17 years.

Changing consumer tastes were only one factor in the collapse. Muir and the company’s current management team blamed Clover’s demise on a restaurant economy that has been reshaped by remote work, inflationary prices, and rising operating costs that have affected all of

Boston.

But Clover’s demise, investors say, was foreshadowed for years. Documents show a visionary company squeezed by mounting financial pressures as management focused on growth.

Ingredient costs, the company said in a newsletter to customers Tuesday night, are 30 to 50 percent more now than just two years ago.

About 170 people will lose their jobs, and leave a hole in the restaurant scene for diners.

“It really seemed like the future of food,” said Kelly Andreoni, a long-

CLOVER, Page A10

Coverage now out of reach for many here

Tens of thousands going without health insurance as premiums in Mass. soar

By Marin Wolf and Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

Tens of thousands of Massachusetts residents dropped health insurance coverage through the Affordable Care Act marketplace this year, a consequence of higher premiums and reduced federal subsidies that had helped make coverage cheaper.

State officials said net enrollment through the ACA exchange, known as the Massachusetts Health Connector, dropped by about 27,500, or around 7 percent, between November and February, and the numbers continue to modestly decline since. Current enrollment is now fewer than 350,000 people.

And a new survey of ACA customers who lost coverage this year found that 58 percent now don’t have health insurance of any kind.

“The trend that we anticipated and worried about has come to bear,” said Health Connector executive director Audrey Morse Gasteier.

Outside an unusual period during the pandemic, nothing in the connector’s history compares to the drop this year, Gasteier said. Nationwide, an estimated 1.2 million fewer people enrolled in the ACA compared to last year.

Cost was the number one reason responders cited for going without insurance, the connector’s survey found. Consumers were faced with a one-two punch: premiums that increased between 7

HEALTH CONNECTOR, Page A7

With help from a big name, Vt. takes on ticket resellers

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

MONTPELIER — Promoting his latest album, “The Great Divide,” Noah Kahan has found himself on “Saturday Night Live,” the cover of Rolling Stone, and the top of the Billboard charts.

The Vermont singer-songwriter has also found time to lobby legislators in the capital of his home state. In April, he testified by video in the Vermont Senate to urge passage of a bill that would crack down on the secondary ticket market, which he believes is ripping off concertgoers.

“As an artist, I care very deeply about the fan experience and accessibility of concert tickets,” Kahan told lawmakers, arguing that the bill, H.512, was “a critical step in eliminating predatory resale behaviors.”

Vermont lawmakers agreed, and on Tuesday, Governor Phil Scott signed the legislation, making Vermont the only state in the country to cap resale prices of tickets for concerts, entertainment, and sporting events at 110 percent of their original value. The new law also bans ticket speculation, where an entity sells a ticket it doesn’t yet own, and other deceptive practices.

TICKETS, Page A7



JOSH REYNOLDS FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Sabuj Barua (center left) of Medford and Monir Mohammed of Stoneham celebrated during a pickup game in Medford.

‘I JUST DON’T FEEL IT HERE IN NEW ENGLAND’

By Omar Mohammed
GLOBE STAFF

MEDFORD — On a recent balmy Sunday evening, the bright spring sun accentuated the grass of Hickey Park, where soccer players of different generations and varying skill levels came together to enjoy a pickup game.

Each of the players, who were mostly South Asian, gave their prediction of who will win the World Cup, which kicks off across North America in a few weeks, with seven matches to be played at Gillette Stadium in Foxborough.

“Morocco!” “Portugal!” “Argentina!” “Brazil!” “Spain!”

Humayun Morshed, a Medford resident who is originally from Bangladesh and a regular at the pickup games, has fond mem-

Whether it’s the sky-high prices or the crackdown on immigrants, World Cup fans fear there’s something missing this time around

ories of the Cup. His ninth-grader son, Ariq, is a huge fan of soccer and really wants to go to a game.

But Morshed has struggled to make the prices work.

“Don’t know if we can afford it. It’s a shame,” he said. “Especially since the games will be right here in our backyard and we may not have a chance to watch.”

For many immigrants, the tournament can be a time to cheer for their countries of origin, and to celebrate the multiculturalism of the American experience. But some soccer lovers in Massachusetts say the thrill of this year’s games is overshadowed by concerns over pricey tickets, the inability of many communities to host watch parties,

WORLD CUP, Page A10

A shining star on and off the court

As a creator of neighborhood basketball league, Roscoe Baker helped heal the city’s racial divide

By Matt Porter
GLOBE STAFF

Rev. Dr. Michael Haynes, of Roxbury’s Twelfth Baptist Church, was immensely passionate about his neighborhood.

APPRECIATION

“There’s gold in the hills of Roxbury,” Rev. Haynes always used to say,” said Alfreda Harris, a Roxbury native, community advocate, and worshiper at Twelfth Baptist. “You talk about athletes — oh my goodness. And just good folks. That’s gold.”

Haynes’s brother, Roscoe Baker, was good as gold.

Tributes flowed last week for Baker, a Roxbury-raised resident of Dorchester who died May 17 of complications from

an April stroke. He was 88.

Friends remembered him as a local basketball star, a community icon, a champion of the city’s young dreamers. One of Boston’s best all-around athletes of the 1950s and ’60s, he spent the following decades showing others how to be great.

“People called him the unofficial mayor of Boston,” said his daughter, Jillian Baker. “He was a tall guy with a big personality who really cared about his students, the community, the homeless, and how sports can be an avenue for youth to excel.”



BAKER, Page C5

“People called him the unofficial mayor of Boston,” said Roscoe Baker’s daughter. Above, he’s second from left on the Roxbury Memorial High team in 1955.



May’d in the shade

Thursday: Showers, cooler. High 65-70. Low 53-58.

Friday: Still damp. High 66-71. Low 50-55. Sunrise: 5:12 Sunset: 8:11

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C9.

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Mayor Michelle Wu laid off the city’s head of green infrastructure and eliminated the office he was leading. **B1.**

About one in six American adults who tested positive for COVID-19 went on to develop long COVID, according to a new study. **D1.**

The Citgo sign will soon go dark for at least six months as crews reconstruct and relocate it. **D1.**

The National Park Service is using \$67 million worth of park entrance fees to help fund President Trump’s beautification projects in D.C. **A2.**

Patriots coach Mike Vrabel said balancing family and football has been going “really good” since the scandal involving him broke. **C1.**